

sa

ISSUE 5, 2021

Homeschooling

LIVING & LEARNING – TOGETHER



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in Covid-19 times

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means to be 'smart'

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Your **feedback is essential** in helping us put together a magazine which delivers on-point content relevant to your homeschooling experiences and support needs and **helps you navigate** your child/children's education with ease and confidence.

You are the **core** of the publication, so let's live and learn together.

Email our editor, Shelagh Foster,
at: shelagh@isikhova.co.za.



sa Homeschooling
LIVING AND LEARNING - TOGETHER

Contents

6

How to raise an adult (and how not to)

Wise, witty and practical advice for helping your child grow into an independent adult

10

Coping with Covid-19 life

Lockdowns, illness, riots... Here's how to take back ownership of your lives



13

Two kinds of smart

The difference between intelligence and knowledge – and why it matters to your child's self-esteem

16

Create a discovery garden

Making a fun outdoor play space can reap great rewards, at very little cost and effort



22

Creative writing – a recipe!

Invaluable tips and tricks for any tween, teen, or adult who wants to be a writer

30

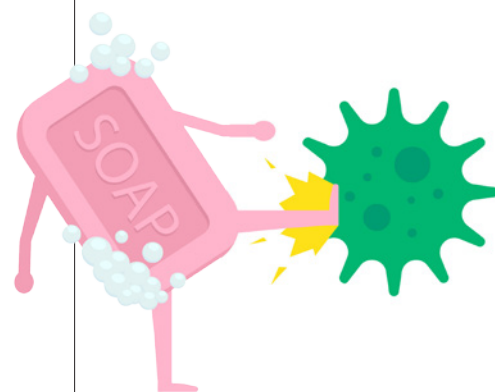
Winning words

Here they are! The clever and delightful winning entries for this round of our Creative Writing competition

33

Rethinking sight words

Everything you need to know to help your child master the trickiness of spelling



36

Bookshelf

A gorgeous children's atlas, excellent resources, schooling readiness and science – all ready for reading time

38

My story

Mom Anneri shares her experience of different teaching and learning styles, and life on the beach

Meet the team

In case you thought I do this all on my own, allow me to introduce the powerhouse behind *SA Homeschooling* mag



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– MANAGING
DIRECTOR

Imraan's winning 18-year Isikhova Media formula combines being people-driven with an honest and mutual respect for both the team and the company's clients. When new ideas and projects come to fruition, he's heard to say: 'Awesomeness!'



JENNY JUSTUS –
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DIRECTOR

Communication and fresh ideas are Jenny's specialities. Her focus on industry growth by working through, and with, people has given her a highly respected platform in advertising sales and strategy. Jenny's ability to renew and reinvigorate our clients' brands is legendary.



JOANNE BROOK
– CREATIVE
DIRECTOR

'Be bold or italic – never regular' is Joanne's mantra. And it's with this unique creativity and eye for excellence that she's been conceptualising and designing with Isikhova Media for 16 years. The best professional advice she's ever received? 'Work hard and be nice to people.'



JASON AARONS
– PUBLISHING
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Jason's greatest survival skill is his sublime sense of absurdity and humour. As an IDEAlist, he's inspired by the creative media magic of the team. One of the original co-founders of the company, he has four decades of media experience and is a strong proponent of networking.



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AND ADMIN

Thuli's known for her warm and positive attitude to life and work. With Isikhova Media for 16 years, the best piece of professional advice she ever received was: 'Never give up in life and always stay positive.' Thuli's incredible memory makes her our very own in-house Google.



RUWAYDA MAHOMED
– MEDIA EXECUTIVE

Ru starts her day with a mantra to feed the soul – and it shows. Her sharp wit and wicked sense of humour are a delight and she sets a supersonic working pace. She describes her job as 'engaging, challenging and fulfilling'. (We suspect this also refer to her legendary *koeksisters*.)



Ed's note

If ever there was a time to be grateful for homeschooling, it's surely now. While loadshedding and lockdowns have hit us all, isn't it good to know that you don't have to deal with 'schools open/schools closed' and getting stuck at dead traffic lights at 7am?

Am I trying to look on the bright side of things? Yes, I am. I'm also delighted to bring you some simply wonderful articles, stories and ideas in this issue of *SAH*. So get over to the contents page to see what delights await you.

Stay sane and safe!

Shelagh

Editor

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Brittany is a former classroom teacher who currently home-educates her five (yes, five!) children. Originally from the USA, she now lives in London, where she blogs and finds joy in walking alongside other families in their homeschooling journeys.

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How to raise an adult (and how not to)

Parents often feel honour-bound to ‘help’ their children in order to ensure their future success. They think that if they allow their children to make too many of their *own* decisions, they might accidentally ‘mess up’ or, God forbid, ‘fail’, writes UK-based homeschooling blogger Brittany Burton

Someone who’s experienced this phenomenon first-hand is Julie Lythcott-Haims, author of [How to Raise an Adult](#) (Griffin) and featured expert in the documentary, [Chasing Childhood](#). For 10 years she was Dean of Students at Stanford University and eventually came up with a checklist based on some of the skills she saw lacking. She concluded that an 18-year-old should be able to:

1. Talk to strangers.
2. Find their way around.
3. Manage their own assignments, workload and deadlines.
4. Contribute to the running of a household.
5. Handle interpersonal problems.
6. Cope with ups and down.
7. Earn and manage money.
8. Take risks.

‘Remember, our kids must be able to do all of these things without resorting to calling a parent on the phone. If they’re calling us to ask how, they don’t have the life skill,’ she adds.

Stranded

At age 16, as a new driver in the USA, I was on my way home from basketball practice and, as I coasted down a hill a couple of kilometres from



my house, the car began to chug. By the time I realised what was going on, it was too late and I just managed to pull over in front of the first massive house in an expensive neighbourhood with a reputation for snobbery. Cellphones weren't around yet and I considered my options. I could walk home, but it was cold and raining, or I could knock on the door and ask to use their phone. I chose the latter and braced myself for a snubbing.

I couldn't have been more mistaken. Not only did this family welcome me in to use their phone, but when I couldn't get hold of my parents, the gentleman offered to go for a litre of petrol and put it in my car. While waiting, I had a pleasant talk with the mother, whose son (a few years older than I and who appeared to

be on the autistic spectrum) asked if I wanted to see his baseball card collection. We looked through his cards and chatted a bit. From the appreciative look on his mother's face, I sensed that social opportunities for this young man were rare. When his father came back, I thanked them all profusely and headed to the petrol station to top up my car.

The ordeal couldn't have lasted more than

'In her research, children stated that they most wanted to be self-reliant; to feel capable, to have ownership over aspects of their life.'



an hour, but in that short time, I learnt important lessons about hospitality, sacrifice, kindness, the patience of a mother, the power of listening, the impact of loneliness, the stereotypes I held about the super-rich and the value of a neighbour. In short, I was humbled.

Based on Lythcott-Haims's research, I don't have to wonder too hard about what a teen today might do in the same situation. She'd call her parents from her mobile phone. If they didn't answer, she'd start calling friends until someone could bail her out. On the slim chance her phone had died, it would be paralyzing, because knocking on a stranger's door would be out of the question. Who knows who could be lurking behind?



I'm not saying it's wrong for children to call their parents and I'd expect my own children to do so, but I also see the lessons that would be missed. And this is our parenting dilemma.

You might think that kids just don't want, or aren't ready for, these responsibilities, but Vicki Hoefle, author of [Duct Tape Parenting](#) (Routledge), found the opposite to be true. In her research, children stated that they most wanted to be self-reliant; to feel capable, to have ownership over aspects of their life.

So why is it so hard for us to let go of responsibilities that our children could easily take on themselves? Hoefle explains that there are underlying beliefs that parents, usually mothers, have about their



children. I admit that I spotted myself in two of the following categories (Nos 2 and 3). What about you?

1. Kids just want, and deserve to have, fun.

Here, parents desire an idyllic childhood for their children that involves not making them do anything that might hamper their enjoyment, like chores and responsibilities.

2. I'm faster, better, neater and a bit of a perfectionist, so it's just easier if I do everything myself.

This is the efficient, probably over-scheduled, mom who doesn't have time for her children to be involved in the process of chores, cooking, etc.

3. If my kids don't look good, behave politely, play fair and do the right thing all the time, I'll look like a slacker parent with loser kids.

My friend Vaneetha calls this 'using our children as billboards'. And it's not a good practice.

4. I don't want my child to grow up and not want me around, so I'll just make sure she needs me enough.

This is the 'Mommy-needs-to-be-needed' syndrome. If your definition of success means high exam marks, elite university acceptance and a high-paying job, then there's little room for choice in your child's life and no



time for failure. If, on the other hand, your desire is for your child to be privately happy and publicly responsible, then the definition of success becomes much broader and it's a whole lot easier to let go of societal expectations and trappings.

Take-home thoughts

- What do I do for my child that they can do on their own?
- Are my children prepared (or on track) for life on their own?
- Do I bail my children out instead of letting them learn via natural consequences and problem-solving?
- Does my definition of success consider who my child is, including their interests and desires, or is it solely dictated by my own interests and desires for them?

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Coping with Covid-19 life

Canadian poet Boonaa Mohammed wrote: ‘Sometimes you find yourself in the middle of chaos, and sometimes in the middle of chaos, you find yourself.’ Well, the first part is certainly familiar, some 17 months and counting into the Covid-19 pandemic. But how do we – as families – ‘find’ ourselves amidst all this madness, particularly when so many of us are feeling hopelessly displaced?

It's not easy. Many of us have lost loved ones, jobs, our freedom of movement and physical connections to families and friends. What was once simply ‘home’ has now become everything – workplace, learning space and relaxation space. Eating out is a rare treat and going to the shops, the play group or extramural activities is a health risk. But there are things we can all do to take back ownership of our lives, to tighten those precious

family bonds, to become mentally ‘unstuck’. All it takes is a little creativity, one extra burst of determination and a huge dollop of hope.

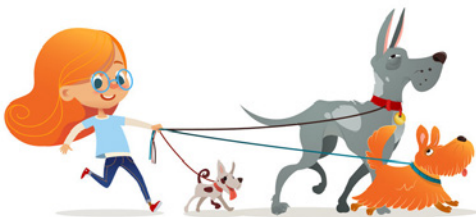
1 Start new family rituals.

The power of ritual can't be over-estimated. Rituals help us feel connected and give us a sense of exclusive belonging; they can soothe, delight and create continuity. Many of our family rituals are small things that we no longer even think about: saying ‘Sleep tight, don't let the bedbugs bite!’ at bedtime; all sitting round the table at supper time to share news of the day, or taking the dog for a family walk.

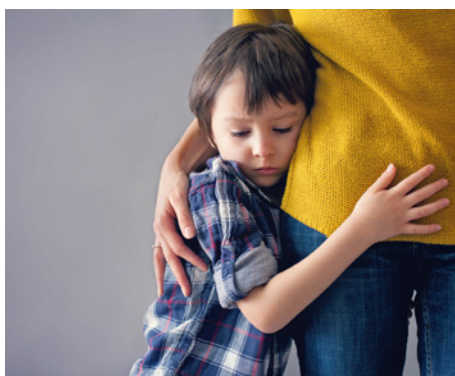
New rituals can help create normality in our not-quite-normal world. A few suggestions: go for a walk around the garden or neighbourhood every day to observe the changes in the trees and plants, perhaps taking photos to record those changes; sing favourite funny songs while you clean up the kitchen; make little artworks and share them on a Sunday morning.

2 Create happy memories.

Make a home movie; create a song and sing it loudly; go on adventure walks wearing silly hats; paint a mural on the hallway wall; have a picnic on the living room floor.



3 Mourn your losses. While it's often easier – particularly for parents – to hide pain, it's important to show your children that grief is allowed. Whether it's something as devastating as the death of a family member or the more manageable loss of not being able to go to Granny's for the holidays, allow your children to express their grief, acknowledging that the pain is real.



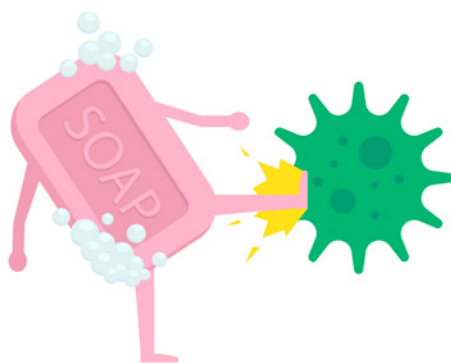
4 Take a break. If you've reached the point of 'I can't do this anymore!', stop doing it and do something different. The world won't come to an end if you decide to take a week off homeschooling, gardening or ironing. Just set a deadline and use the time to reconnect with yourself and your family.

5 Change things. They say that 'a change is as good as a holiday', so why not use this time to rearrange the furniture, swap the dining area with the sitting area or turn your garden into a discovery playground? (*More of this on p17!*)

6 Talk about difficult subjects. While younger children are more likely to be concerned about immediate events ('Why are you always so grumpy?' 'Why can't I have a birthday party?'), tweens and teens are inclined to worry deeply about the future. Don't be afraid to have those difficult conversations. Recognise their concerns and be honest about what you do and don't know, and what can and can't be changed. Discuss how to make your lives better in any ways you can.

7 Stay informed and use this as an opportunity to teach older children to discern between real and fake news. Help your children to stay in control. This [link](#) offers more sound advice on how to do that.

8 Turn this virus into a science and art project. This may seem a whacky idea, but that old adage, 'Better the devil you know than the one you don't know', has seldom been more applicable. If your children



can understand, even on a basic level, how viruses work and what they look like, it's easier to accept the reality, so make it a research project and encourage your kids to paint or draw the virus and learn the names of its various parts.

9 Seek medical advice if life is unmanageable for you or your children.

The pressure to cope is enormous. Somehow we're all supposed to get on with it, answering 'fine' every time we're asked how we're doing. Many of us *aren't* fine and the best thing to do if you fall into this category is ask your doctor for advice or assistance.



10 Express gratitude. Recognising and honouring the beautiful things in life has the power to make us see more things to be thankful for – even when we're battling. Give it a go. And stay strong.

For more information, we recommend this excellent www.gov.za booklet.



New ADvTECH school offering set to revolutionise online education

Opening its virtual doors to learners from Grade R to Grade 9, from January 2021, ADvTECH's new online offering, Evolve Online School (Evolve), will change the face of online schooling in South Africa.

'In this rapidly changing society, the one-size-fits-all method of teaching no longer makes any sense,' says principal Colin Northmore. 'Evolve starts by answering the question: how can we make learning an adventure for each child?'

Evolve combines a user-experience focus with a trendsetting curriculum mapping system, developed at MIT, to personalise each child's learning experience. Using the latest research, each child's learning journey will be designed based on exclusive subject and skill maps.

Students will be placed within subjects according to their abilities, letting them progress faster where they're gifted and work at a more deliberate pace to master content they find more challenging. The result is that each student's learning experience is tailored to their specific needs and they're encouraged to grow at a pace that suits their ability and enthusiasm.

'There'll be a strong focus on foundational, social and emotional learning skills. Our team of life coaches will focus exclusively on these skills. Our children are growing up in a world very different from the one in which



we grew up. Things that we, as adults, deal with and take in our stride, they're already facing at a very young age. Our life coaches will play a very important role in teaching students how to deal with issues such as stress and anxiety, and help them develop coping mechanisms, resilience and a growth mindset,' adds Northmore.

Evolve will make use of the following:

- **Diagnostic testing** to determine the exact level of proficiency of a student before

placement and during the educational journey.

- **Asynchronous learning** so that learners can move through content at their own pace and according to their own proficiency. Students will also have direct access to their teachers, who'll facilitate extra activation classes.
- **Synchronous learning**, where our students will also be able to attend live interactive classes, making this a true online school.
- **Socialisation opportunities** with academies, studios and day camps monthly so that students can meet other 'Evolvers' and get green time to balance their screen time.

Now enrolling for 2021.

The school will cater for Grades R-9 from January 2021. Grades 10-12 will be phased in from 2022. ADvTECH is Africa's largest private education provider. Its schools division includes iconic brands such as Crawford Schools, Trinityhouse and Abbotts.

Visit: www.evolveonline.co.za for more information or email: info@evolveonline.co.za.

We've all done this before and every time, it's accompanied by an overwhelming feeling of pride: we've called our kids 'smart' for achieving an extraordinary academic result. The 'extraordinary' is reflected by what you expect and what your kid is capable of.

For a child struggling with academic concepts like learning, reading and/or maths, however, being told that they, too, are smart can be a rare or completely absent phenomenon.

For many parents (and educators), the traditional and most common definition of smart is to be good at learning and remembering things, resulting in academic achievements. When children do well at school and get good grades, we usually call them smart. But – and there's always a 'but' – in real life, things are a little more complicated.

Being smart goes beyond schoolwork and/or academic performance, or simply getting good grades. In fact, people can be smart in different ways.

Just because a child can remember maths formulae or the timeline of World War II doesn't necessarily mean they're smart. Likewise a child who struggles with a specific aspect of learning isn't necessarily *not* smart.



Two kinds of smart

What do children need for them to succeed: knowledge, or intelligence? And what's the difference?

Dalene van der Westhuizen explores the dual meaning of 'smart'

There are actually two parts to smart – *knowledge* and *intelligence* – and we need both of them.

Knowledge is the collection of skills and information a person has acquired through studies and related experience.

Intelligence, on the other hand, is the ability to *apply* knowledge. Just because someone lacks knowledge of a particular subject doesn't mean they can't apply their intelligence to help solve a problem.

The stakes are high

If we look at the World Economic

Forum's list of critical skills for the future, it's clear that our kids need more than good grades. They'll need to be more than just 'book-smart'. They'll need to be able to apply the knowledge they have.

Book-smart children can list facts and data, but don't necessarily have a deeper comprehension/ understanding of the topic. They may have a lot of general knowledge and do well in quizzes or tests, but they might struggle with more complex applications. On the other hand, intelligence – or our ability to process information – helps us acquire knowledge and skills, and apply the two as a combined effort.

Intelligence includes the capacity for understanding things, self-awareness, applying logic, reasoning, problem-solving, creativity, planning, etc.

According to the World Economic Forum:

- Critical thinking and problem-solving top the list of skills

'Intelligence includes the capacity for understanding things, self-awareness, applying logic, reasoning, problem-solving, creativity, planning, etc.'



employers believe will grow in prominence in the coming years across the globe.

- Newly emerging this year are skills in self-management such as active learning, resilience, stress tolerance and flexibility.

So what does that imply for our children and their futures?

Simply getting good grades, without understanding or being able to apply that knowledge component, is meaningless. Similarly, the

way your brain processes, stores and uses information can be strengthened and developed to make learning (including attention, reading, maths, etc) easier.

Tomorrow depends on what you know and do today

We know that homeschools and traditional schools are responsible for the transfer of knowledge within a curriculum framework. However, who is responsible for intelligence?

Intervention through appropriate skills testing and training can open up a whole new world of possibilities – ones never dreamed of.

Through ongoing international research and a constantly increasing global focus on improving brain skills, we have the science, research and know-how to improve and develop areas such as processing speed, memory, attention, visual and auditory processing, as well as logic and reasoning.



Changes in these cognitive areas positively impact intelligence.

A growing body of research suggests that stimulating the mind with intensive, research-based mental exercise will cause brain cells, called neurons, to branch



widely. This branching effect causes millions of additional connections, or synapses, between brain cells.

Arnold Scheibel, the former Director of UCLA's Brain Research Institute, once said: 'We can think of it as upgrading a computer with a bigger memory board that allows you to do more things more quickly.'

The question is therefore no longer 'Can intelligence be changed?' The clear answer to this is 'Yes!' 'Yes' in the support of struggling students, but also 'yes' in the support of average and exceptional students. This could benefit all students at all levels of performance.

A new focus

As parents and educators, let's consciously decide to move away from only focusing on our children's grades and rather ensure that they're able to understand and apply the knowledge they work so hard to acquire.

Let's help and enable them with a strong combined 'smart' advantage of both knowledge and intelligence. This is a skill for life.

In the next issue of *SAH*, we'll unpack **executive functions**, the impact they have on learning and daily life, and what parents can do at home to strengthen those skills.

Until then, happy reading!

Top 10 skills of 2025

WORLD ECONOMIC FORUM

-  Analytical thinking and innovation
-  Active learning and learning strategies
-  Complex problem-solving
-  Critical thinking and analysis
-  Creativity, originality and initiative
-  Leadership and social influence
-  Technology use, monitoring and control
-  Technology design and programming
-  Resilience, stress tolerance and flexibility
-  Reasoning, problem-solving and ideation

Type of skill

-  Problem-solving
-  Self-management
-  Working with people
-  Technology use and development

Source: Future of Jobs Report 2020, World Economic Forum.



KNOWLEDGE

Information gained from learning, studying, and memorising academic material such as historical facts, grammar, mathematical equations, etc. Measured by tests, exams, grades, etc.

INTELLIGENCE

The brain's ability to process and use information. Includes things like spatial reasoning, logical ability, etc. Can be increased by strengthening cognitive skills. Measured by IQ or Cognitive Tests.

Create a discovery garden





Gardens are many things: places to grow, quiet spaces to go to, lawns to stroll on, flowers to pick and veggies to eat. But they can also be magical places filled with imagination, discovery and adventure for children. We share some ideas on how to make that happen

Firstly, you need to allocate a space. If possible, try to make it close to the house, or at least visible from where you normally spend your day. It would also be handy if your child had access to a tap to rinse off most of the mud before coming inside.

Then think about what your children most love doing; how they normally play. Are they highly creative? Boisterous? Do they like to potter on their own, or with others? Are they physically fearless, or do they prefer gentle play?

The basics

Water. While you might not have the resources – or energy – to instal a fountain or build a stream, a large, shallow metal basin or



plastic paddling pool, or even just a sprinkler can do the trick. Then add items such as a sieve, plastic jugs, bottles, tubes, water pistols and blocks. A squirt of garden-friendly dishwashing liquid will add to the fun.

Art. How about creating an outdoor blackboard – either on an existing wall or a sturdy board? Although normal blackboard paint won't work outside, black exterior latex paint will. Alternatively, you can try this trick from the legendary Martha Stewart: mix 1 cup of black exterior paint with 2 tablespoons of black tile grout for a surface that will last many seasons. And don't forget to paint

the back and sides of the board to prevent weathering.

Hideaways. All children need a den; a space to be alone to dream and make sense of the world, or to hang out with friends for some serious kids' talk. This could be a small tent (possibly one of the best buys you'll ever make), an old groundsheet draped over a branch or – if your finances will stretch – a little Wendy house or shed.

Climbables. A study by www.playcore.com found that climbing at a young age helps hone spatial and directional awareness, and boosts physical skills such as balance, hand and foot co-ordination, and agility. A jungle gym is first prize, but a rope ladder suspended from a tree branch or swing frame comes a close second. As do logs and rocks large enough to be scrambled up and clambered over.



Edibles. Teaching children to grow their own vegetables and herbs is a sure-fire way of encouraging them to actually eat them. Basil, organum, baby spinach, marjoram, baby tomatoes, mint, spring onions, beans, cabbage and sugar

snap peas are all easy to grow – and easy on the palate.

To make it extra-fun, get your little ones involved in the digging, planting and watering. And eating.

Textures. Why do children love mud so much? Perhaps because they can make it, feel it, spread it, stomp in it, squish it – and freak their parents out with it! Who knows? But the bottom line is that where there is soil, there shall be mud, so why not dedicate one little patch of ground purely for the fun of it?

Sand is a little more forgiving and even the smallest sandpit can offer hours of all-year-round creative and imaginative joy.

Our feet are 'designed' to deal with uneven surfaces, so let kids go barefoot whenever possible. Walking on stones and pebbles helps children improve balance and stability.

If you do decide to go ahead and make a discovery garden (or already have), we'd love to see photos. Feel free to send them to: sahomeschooling@isikhova.co.za

‘Children enhance their gross motor skills, co-ordination and physical fitness through lifting, pouring, carrying, running and splashing, while actions such as squeezing help to develop the small muscles in a child’s hands.’ – busybees.edu.au



"Every child is a different kind of flower and all together make this world a beautiful garden."

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STEM stuff

[The Sci-Bono Discovery Centre](#), southern Africa's largest science centre, is affiliated to the Gauteng Department of Education to support maths, science and technology education. It's also huge fun and utterly fascinating.

Resources

[Teacha.co.za](#) is an online marketplace for more than 3 000 South African teaching resources, many of which are free.



Right minds

Late-night online 'study sessions' in economics, accounting, maths and science; the lives of sportspeople and athletes; African literature; storytime for littlies... [Mindset Africa](#) will blow you away with its excellent offerings.



History buffs

Looking for topics, articles, example questions and answers based on the Curriculum Assessment Policy Statement? [The History Classroom](#) explores local and global historical events, while also dealing with African history.

More than music

[Chrome Music Lab](#) enables children to explore music and its connections to maths, science and art. This highly visual tool is organised in experiments and is both engaging and easy to use.



Field trips

Join the Explorer Classroom or take a tour of the Inter-national Space Station with virtual field trips and virtual world tours. Alternatively, explore more educational virtual tours with [TripSavvy's](#) online list of children's museums.

Storytime

[Storyline](#) is an award-winning children's literacy website that features famous people reading beloved children's books. Kids can listen to the story, follow the words and enjoy the colourful animations.



Jozi delight

Everyone's favourite bunny comes to life in Peter Rabbit and Me at National Children's Theatre's Outdoor IMAGINATION Theatre in Johannesburg. A delightful dramatisation of the beloved story of Peter Rabbit by Beatrix Potter. Bring your masks, ground cover, low chairs, blankets and picnic basket, and enjoy an unforgettable outing. Suitable for aged three and up. Book [here](#). Sunday August 22, 11:00 - Sunday September 26.

Spatulatta

This is a [website](#) where kids teach kids to cook. Its main goals are to foster peer-to-peer learning, healthy eating, and teaching children life skills. You're guaranteed kids on kitchen duty!

Play Africa

[Play Africa](#) is the first interactive children's play and early education museum of its kind in southern Africa. Online you'll find activity packs including 'Imagination and Colouring', 'Super Scientists Kit', 'Kindness Tree', Science at Home' – four different packs. There's also a great section on African storytelling with stories like 'The Hyena who could not stop laughing', 'The Musical Tree' and Children of the Stars (Bana ba Dinalledi). And so much more!



Gem kids

This is a [gem of a find!](#) It will give you and your kids a glimpse into how gems form, how they are crafted into beautiful objects, and give you a sneak peek into the history of some of the world's rarest treasures. In doing so, your kids will learn to love gemology – that's the science of gemstones and appreciate the unique beauty of gems.

Brain box

[The Smithsonian Learning Lab](#) offers amazing images, texts, videos, audio recordings and learning activities in its collection of more than one million artefacts.



Make me a Genius

This [website](#) has converted an array of school topics into short cartoon movies and uses day-to-day examples in all its videos so kids can approach learning in a logical way. There are cool facts for kids, educational power points including math, the solar system, oceans, food nutrition and so much more! Other range from environmental science, the human body, animals, plants, chemistry, physics and general knowledge.



Creative writing – a recipe!

So you want to be a writer? Jo'burg-based Jo Macgregor, best-selling international author of 16 books – including YA titles *The Law of Tall Girls*, *Hushed*, *Scarred*, *Recoil*, *Refuse* and *Rebel* – offers some of the best writing advice you'll ever read

You know the feeling. You're sitting at your desk, staring at a blank page or screen, knowing you have to write that creative essay, but you don't have a cooking clue where to begin.

Would you like a recipe to follow? Yes? Okay, then, here we go...

Ingredients. Every good story has a handful of key ingredients. For yours, you will need:

A flavoursome idea. Usually, this starts with a 'What if...?' thought. ('What if a boy is a wizard, but he doesn't know it?' 'What if a girl's younger sister is chosen to fight to the death in an arena?' 'What if my boyfriend dumped me and I wanted revenge?')

Pick something that puzzles, interests or amuses you, or something you feel strongly about.

Good places to find ideas are in the news, dreams, photographs and overheard conversations!

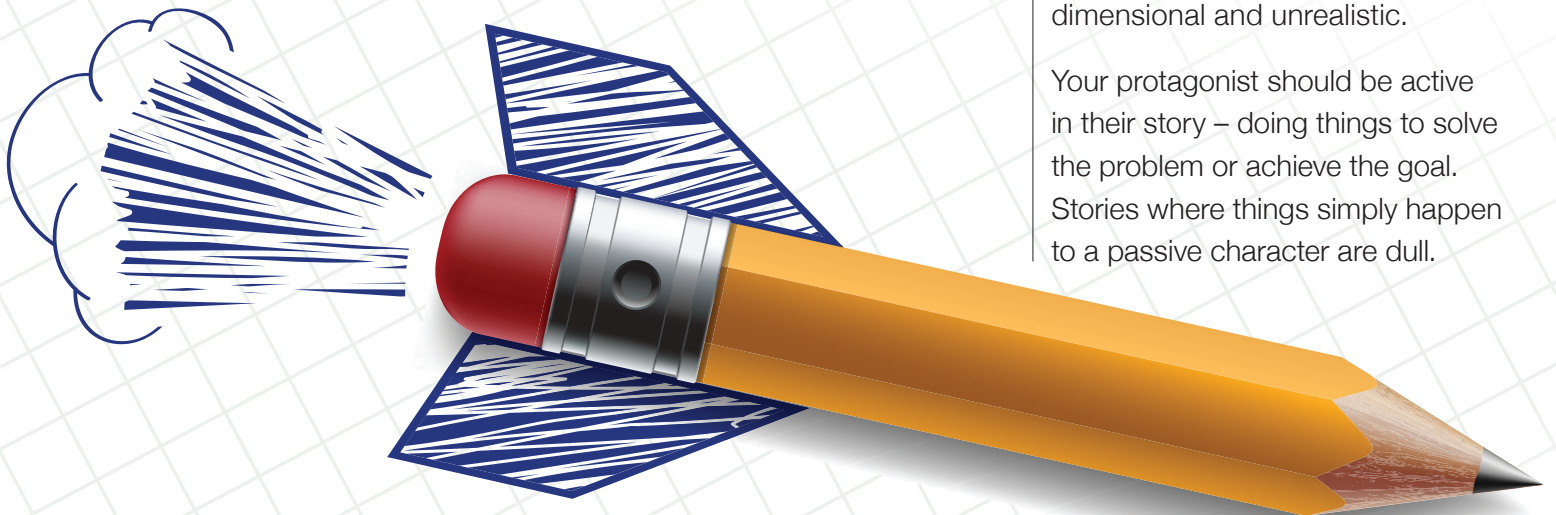


One or more tasty characters.

Every story needs at least a protagonist (the main character whose story you're telling), but compelling stories also have an antagonist (the baddie, the hero's opponent), as well as other characters like a sidekick friend or love interest.

Make sure that your protagonist has a couple of interesting flaws (eg a bad temper, a troubled past, a fear of heights) and that your antagonist has some good qualities (they love animals, stop to help an old lady across the road, hate corruption, etc), otherwise they can become boringly one-dimensional and unrealistic.

Your protagonist should be active in their story – doing things to solve the problem or achieve the goal. Stories where things simply happen to a passive character are dull.



A spicy plot. The plot is what happens in the story. Someone wants something and has a hard time getting it.

It usually follows a structure:

- a beginning (sets the scene and shows the character in their normal, everyday life);
- an instigating event (something happens that changes everything);
- a middle (the protagonist deals with challenges, conflicts and complications);
- and an ending (an exciting climax in which the protagonist does or doesn't achieve the goal, usually learning a lesson in the process, and a resolution when the action winds down).

Make sure that what happens is sparked or caused by what happened before. Your story shouldn't be a series of events (this happened, then that happened and then something else happened), but rather a sequence of logically connected scenes (this happened and because of that, the next thing happened, which caused the next thing).

Pixar, the computer animation company behind wonderful movies like *Toy Story*, *Up* and *Monsters Inc.*, has this simple recipe for its stories: 'Once upon a time there was... And every day... Then one day... And because of that... And because of that... Until finally... The end.'



'As you read, you automatically absorb an understanding of character, story structure and conflict. The more you read, the better you'll write.'

A splash of setting. Choose a place, time and season in which your story takes place. The setting can be big (Mars) or small (the family dinner table). Are there any special rules in this society? What are the terrain and weather like? When you describe what it looks like, include specific details (the rocky red earth, burnt rice and congealed gravy) to help your reader picture the story in their mind's eye.

A cup of conflict. What does the protagonist need to overcome to achieve the goal? Make it hard for them! Opposition can be external (an enemy), internal (cowardice, guilt, fear), societal (the



oppressive regime, poverty) or even environmental (a storm outside, a meteor headed for earth).

A point of view (POV). This is the perspective from which the story is told.

The most common POVs are first person ('I climbed onto my broomstick and flew, while my friend cheered') and third person ('He climbed onto his broomstick and flew, while his friend cheered'). Writing from one person's perspective makes it easier to describe the character's feelings and thoughts, but it means you're limited to what that character sees or hears (or overhears).

It's helpful to think of POV as a camera: from whose eyes are we seeing the scene?

A spoonful of tone. This is the overall feel of your story: is it going to be funny or sad, serious, heartwarming or hopeful?

Method

1. Put on your writer's hat. Combine all the ingredients and see what develops without worrying about how well you're writing.
2. Finish the story.
3. Now put on your editor's hat. Go back and check for mistakes and places where you can improve the writing.
4. Congratulate yourself on writing a terrific tale!



HOT TIPS

- 1 The best writers are voracious readers. As you read, you automatically absorb an understanding of character, story structure and conflict. The more you read, the better you'll write.
- 2 Write what you know. It's super-difficult to write about things you know little about, unless you're prepared to do lots of research. For short school essays, it's useful to keep the story smaller and write about conflicts you know well (a fight between friends, annoying siblings, a holiday romance, a car hijacking).
- 3 Don't start your story with 'It was a dark and stormy night...' and don't end it with 'I woke up and my coffee was cold – it had all been a dream!' Try to find fresh ways of saying things, rather than using tired, old clichés.
- 4 The best writing advice I ever got was from my Grade 11 English teacher, who told me: 'Just begin.' She was right. Starting is the hardest part. Just start somewhere and keep going – you can always go back and fix it later.

Just begin. You never know – you might be the next JK Rowling or Anthony Horowitz!

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SA homeschoolers! We're thrilled to announce our 2021 Children's Creative Writing Competition.

This is a wonderful opportunity for your child to showcase their writing skills and creativity in an exciting and fun way. Entries can be either fiction or non-fiction and there's no specific topic.

The competition will run from this issue through to Issue 7.

The winning piece from each age group below will be published in the subsequent issue (we will amend any minor spelling or grammar errors). Each will win terrific prizes from Jonathan Ball Publishers and Pearson South Africa, our competition sponsors.

A grand 'surprise' prize for each age category will then be selected and announced in Issue 9.

SAH's 2021 Children's Creative Writing Competition

HOW TO ENTER

There are three age categories:

- 8-10 years
- 11-13 years
- 14-17 years

The submission must not exceed 400 words and should be written either in a Word doc or the body of the email. This competition is open to subscribed readers only. If you've not yet subscribed, please email: sahomeschooling@isikhova.co.za with 'subscribe' in the subject line.

Email sahomeschooling@isikhova.co.za with 'Creative Writing – Your Child's Name' in the subject line, along with the following in the body of the email:

- Your full name
- Contact number
- Your child's name
- Your child's age
- Title of written piece

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Creative writing competition first-round winners

We were absolutely bowled over by the ingenuity, creativity and standard of all the entries. There are two more rounds to go, so get your kids' imaginations fired up and enter now!

Realm seer

By Jordan Mikha Prince, age 15

In a small hut, beside the beaches of the Greenery coast, in the kingdom of House Rosedell, sat a dishevelled old man, lost in his studies. On his desk sat a large stack of books.

He flipped through an old text, written by a civilization that had died out long ago. He was searching for the reason for their society's demise. He sighed in exhaustion. But this had to be done, for he knew something that no one else did: that there was something special about their demise. It wasn't natural. It wasn't caused by mortal beings. This was the doing of some divine entity, but why? Why would the gods fret with the doings and goings of mortal, inconsequential beings? Unless they knew something, something the gods didn't want them to know.

Well this was his theory, but he needed more information.

Later in the afternoon he decided to get some fresh air; he put on his coat and went out into the Autumn breeze. He took a stroll into the Greenery Forest. He had been strolling aimlessly, collecting small rocks and stones when suddenly he heard a small rumble in the bushes beside him. He stopped and took one of the stones and threw it at one of the bushes. It rumbled again. He placed his hand on the hilt of his blade. He threw another one and out jumped a small girl.

She held her hand to her head and said, 'Hey, why don't you throw a couple more, why don't you?'

In a low gravelly voice the man asked, 'What are you doing out here? It's dangerous out here.'

She looked at him. 'What do you mean, dangerous?'

He replied, 'There are things you'd dare not want to see.'

She tilted her head. 'What do you mean, thin...?' She was interrupted by the sound of a flock of birds rushing away.

The man looked at her. 'We aren't alone,' he said, unsheathing his sword.

Just then, cascading towards him, came a large arrow. In one swift motion he sliced it in half. Out of the trees, crawled three dead-walkers, soulless beings wandering aimlessly through the realm. He moved swiftly through them and all of them fell to the ground. His hand began to glow blue, revealing a small symbol on their heads.

The frightened girl behind him, frozen in shock, stared at him 'What are you?'

The end

What the judges said

Jordan shows great maturity and imagination in his writing. We love how clearly he described the scene and how he built such tension in so few words. What a cliffhanger!

A Punctuation-free world

By Sophia de Lange, age 13

The hyphen, the comma, parentheses, capital letters, the full stop and more. I recently went on a journey to showcase the impossibility of a world with no punctuation.

It felt like a dream or something out of this world. I first noticed these important marks were missing when I was addressed a letter. My name was not capitalized. I felt demeaned as if the sender did not think of me as important enough to have my name capitalized. As I read the letter, I experienced a feeling of confusion, there were no commas between lists, no full stops or capital letters, and ideas interrupted the main sentence with no parentheses. I pushed this aside thinking that the writer had terrible grammar and continued with my day.

I quickly noticed that this was not the case. As I read the newspaper, cereal box, and the weather forecast, I noticed the complete absence of any punctuation. I decided to do the final test, I drew a few punctuation marks and capital letters on

a piece of paper and asked my family what they were. As I expected, they knew nothing about these curious markings.

I wanted to see if this would make writing easier or harder. I started this quest by reading my art assignment. I had to draw a picture of a brick wall, student desk, and baby boy, but with no commas I did not know if I should draw a brick wall, or a brick and a wall, and so forth. In a newspaper article, the reporter stated that Violet said, 'I was so happy when I received the donation.' Violet, however, was not capitalized so it sounded as though the colour violet said something, which would be impossible. There were also no quotation marks or commas, so you would not know if those were Violet's direct words.

Suddenly I heard my name being called, and I was no longer in my living room, but in my English class. I looked at my teacher, embarrassed because she probably called me five times. She laughed it off and said, 'To conclude our quiz on language mechanics, would you please explain why punctuation is important.' I had not a second of

hesitation, and told of everything I learned in my... What was it, a daydream? Whatever it was I learned that if punctuation did not exist, we would get extremely confused.

The end



What the judges said

This story was both clever and funny. Sophia obvious loves both punctuation and language and she wielded both with the craft of a seasoned writer. This story should appear in grammar textbooks!

Game reserve adventure By Shanon Strauss, age 10

Levi, my family and I were in the Kruger. It was a hot, beautiful night. The stars scattered the night sky like a floor when a baby is giving glitter and left alone.

We were finishing our food when we got some very, very, very, very, (you get the point) bad news. There was a poacher in town. The message came on Dad's WhatsApp: 'Help if you can.'

My brother Zac screamed, 'WHYY YYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYYY YYYYYY?'

'Zac, stop!' said Dad.

'How can we help?' asked Levi and I in unison.

'Jinx,' Levi and I said in unison. We said 'jinx' again. This went on for quite a while. Twenty-three minutes later dad shouted, 'Enough you two. This is serious.'

'Let's discuss this tomorrow,' said Mom.

'I have an idea,' I said.

'What's the idea?' Levi asked.

'We make a fake rhino. Then we put it sleeping somewhere. We will

put a trap all around the rhino so when the poacher shoots it and comes to get the horn, he will fall in the trap.'

'How will we do this?' asked mom.

Dad said, 'In the whatsapp it said the poacher is a wanted criminal. I'm sure the police will help us make a fake rhino.'

Three days later we had completed the replica rhino with the help of the police engineers. One of them suggested that we should make the inside have water with red food colouring, so when the poacher shoots the rhino the red water will come out and he will think it's blood. The trap was set. It was now a waiting game.

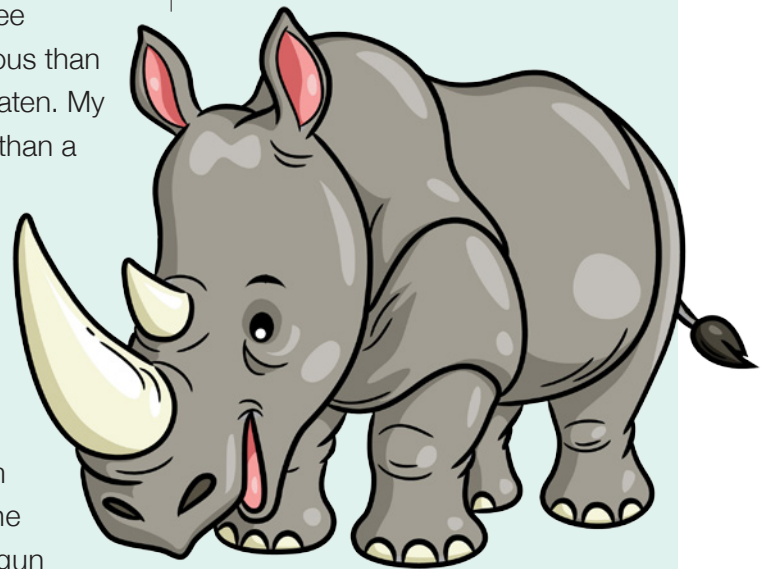
We hid a camera in a tree nearby. I felt more nervous than an apple about to get eaten. My heart was racing faster than a Lamborghini Veneno. Just as we were starting to get bored watching the camera, we heard footsteps.

Suddenly I heard a loud BANG. Since I am a gun expert, I knew the poacher had a P90 (a gun

favoured by poachers). We then heard a loud CLANK! The sound of his gun breaking into pieces as he fell into the hole we had dug in front of the rhino. My plan had worked! I was ecstatic. Happier than a child in a toy shop with an unlimited budget.

The police were watching with us and congratulated me on my successful plan. They went to the hole to arrest the man. Later that day, we were invited to the town hall to be rewarded seven million rand for catching a wanted criminal. The money was great, but what made me the happiest was that the poacher would be behind bars and I had saved the rhinos.

The end



What the judges said

Shanon achieved the almost impossible here, by writing a rollicking adventure in so few words. The pace was wild (see what we did there?) and the original similes were clever and to the point.



Rethinking sight words

In the next in her fascinating series, reading specialist **Marian Bailey** shares invaluable advice on the most straightforward way to teach sight words to young children

Sight words, often referred to as high-frequency, irregular or popcorn words, are traditionally taught by expecting a child to memorise the whole word by sight. However, that's neither an efficient nor an effective way of learning to read words; even words that have one irregular part or a silent letter. For example: with the words *the*, *said* and *know*, because the science of reading tells us that we don't learn whole words, we learn letters and letter strings that correspond to speech sounds.

So, even though sight words have generally been learnt as whole words by sight, they can be decoded. And the parts that can't be decoded can be memorised using the heart method.

Common words such as *and*, *at*, *it*, *can* and *up* – and those that have irregular spellings, such as *said* and *the* – can be taught using phoneme-grapheme mapping (sound to letter) as in steps 1-8 below.

This might all sound very complicated, but once you follow the steps, you and your child will get the hang of it.

The format of phoneme-grapheme mapping is:

- Say the word.
- Echo the word.
- Tap the word.
- Pop the word.



- Slide the word.
- Draw sound lines of the word.
- Spell the word.

For example, to teach the word *said*, use the following steps:

Step 1

The parent says the word *said*.

Step 2

The child echoes the word *said*.

Step 3

The child taps out the word *said* on their fingers (one sound, one finger – /s/ /e/ /d/).

Step 4

Pop the sounds in *said* using a [pop it fidget](#) – /s/ /e/ /d/.

Step 5

Use a manipulative such as pom-poms, counters, [unifix cubes](#) and a sound box. Pull down the sounds in the word *said* into the box. One sound (not letter) in one box.

Step 6

On a whiteboard or blackboard, write three sound lines for each sound in *said*: _ _ _

Step 7

Listen to the word *said*. What is the first sound you hear? /s/. What is the last sound you hear? /d/. The middle sound sounds like a short /e/, but we spell it *ai* in this word – and that's the part we need to learn by heart.



Step 8

Put a heart above the letters *ai* to remind the child that that's the part – and only that part needs to

be memorised. The first and last sounds are decodable.

This allows the child to use their decoding skills to work out part of the word, so they only need to memorise a small part, not the entire word.

Other examples are *what* and *have*.



There are some words that come up all the time when a child is beginning to learn to read, such as *the*, *is*, *was*, *of* and *so*. If children are shown how the letters and sounds correspond, they're far more likely to be able to recall these common words faster, thus enabling them to read and spell them right from the start.

According to the *Science of Reading*, once a word no longer needs to be decoded, it is in fact a sight word. For a fluent reader, all words are sight words. Using the phoneme to grapheme mapping method for all words, including irregular ones, is the way every word will become a sight word for a child learning to read.

STOP memorising irregular words. START mapping them instead and see the results.

- For more information on teaching a child to read using the structured literacy approach, contact: marian@raisingreaders.co.za





Wall of Wisdom

‘The time will come when our nation will honour the memory of all the sons, the daughters, the mothers, the fathers, the youth and the children who, by their thoughts and deeds, gave us the right to assert with pride that we are South Africans, that we are Africans, and that we are citizens of the world.’

– *Nelson Rolihlahla Mandela*
(1918-2013)

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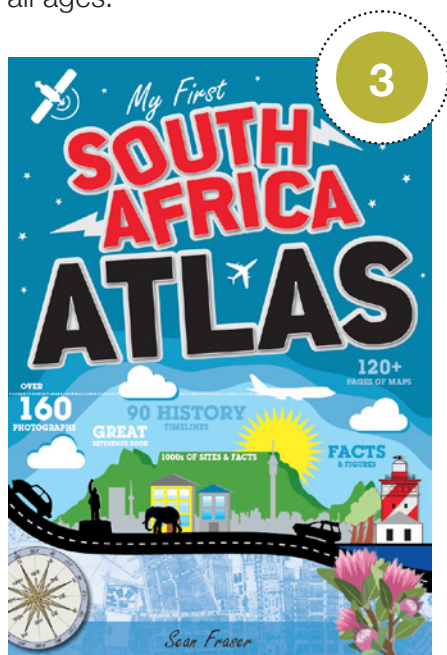


2. *Learn to Read & Write: A Parent's Guide* (Pearson, R140)

You'll love this easy-to-navigate book, packed with valuable information and easy activity sheets that will make your child's learning journey a delight. It all starts with a comfortable lap and 'once upon a time'.

3. *My First South Africa Atlas* (Map Studio, R150)

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5. *Step Into Science: Grade R & ECD, Foundation Phase* (Macmillan Education)

Does the thought of teaching your child science fill you with dread? Well, you don't need to be a science teacher to use these fun, fascinating activity books. They're jam-packed with tips, notes and clear explanations, and the resources are all affordable and easy to source. Just don't blow up the house!



4. *Am I Ready for School?* (Pearson, R160)

'When should I start homeschooling my child?' is an often-asked question. Using worksheets and activities, this comprehensive guide will help you understand your little one's readiness in terms of their emotional, physical and mental development, plus what to do and where to go if you feel they might need support with any of those aspects.



Learning to love teaching

In this issue we chat to Anneri Chudleigh, mom to 15-year-old Gwen, about their respective teaching and learning styles – and why these matter

Why did you start homeschooling?

In Grade 2 my daughter started struggling with reading and writing. She was diagnosed with central auditory processing disorder [CAPD] and ADD. We live in St Lucia, far from remedial schools, and background noise affected her, so a classroom setting wasn't going to work anyway. I really had no option but to homeschool.

What challenges have you faced?

After taking her out of school, I bought a box curriculum. I was

worried that she'd miss valuable school days if we waited until I had a better grasp of how to homeschool and what CAPD was all about. That was a waste of money and caused unnecessary stress to both of us. I wish I'd known about unschooling then, because that was actually what we needed to do. We needed time to find our feet and break off my mainstream education mindset.

Since then, finding a suitable curriculum that accommodates my daughter's learning challenges – and that I'd enjoy teaching – have been my main challenges.

What are the pros and cons of living in a small town?

It's perfect for the primary years. We live at the coast, with lovely forest trails leading from our house. Wildlife and conservation issues are part of our daily walk. Kids learn so much from nature: it really is the best school. But living in a small town with a teen is more challenging. It can be very isolating and all extramural activities require more than an hour's travel.

What's your homeschooling style?

Early in our journey, I found that, because I don't handle clutter very well, I easily lost my train of thought when I had to juggle various open books during a lesson. I got really flustered and by the time I was back on track, I'd lost my daughter's interest.

I also got lost trying to teach from a curriculum, where you're given a basic skeleton framework and have to add to it as you go through the lesson. I find too many options overwhelming and I need a clear-cut goal and a straight path in order to focus.



Important as it was to consider my daughter's unique curriculum needs, I also had to consider my own need for logical, step-by-step, structured lesson plans.

Do you think homeschooling programmes take note of parents' styles?

Definitely not. I recently came across an article on linear vs global thinking styles, which made me realise that there must be other parents like me, struggling to teach a curriculum based on a thinking style opposed to their own. It just doesn't flow. Sadly, this is almost never mentioned in curriculum reviews and sample lessons don't always give you clear insight into how the lessons are structured, so you might end up with an expensive curriculum that doesn't work for you.

How do you prepare Gwen for life after homeschooling?

As a single mom who's running a business from home, I need her

to help out when I have deadlines. She has business and domestic skills way beyond her years. Career-wise, she leans towards web development or graphic design and is currently doing courses on Adobe Creative Suite. She helps with small graphic designing jobs I need done, maintains my sister's business social media pages and builds basic websites for pocket money. With a little help from assistive writing technology, I'm not too stressed about her life after school. However, we're working towards matriculation exemption, as she wants all her options open.

What message would you like to share with other homeschooling families?

The beauty of homeschooling is that we can build our children's education around their (and our) individual needs and interests. To me, inspiring a love of learning in our children is even more important than the actual learning. However, that can't happen if we don't enjoy teaching, so I'd encourage parents – especially those new to homeschooling – to identify their thinking styles and focus on their own needs as well when choosing a curriculum.



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